

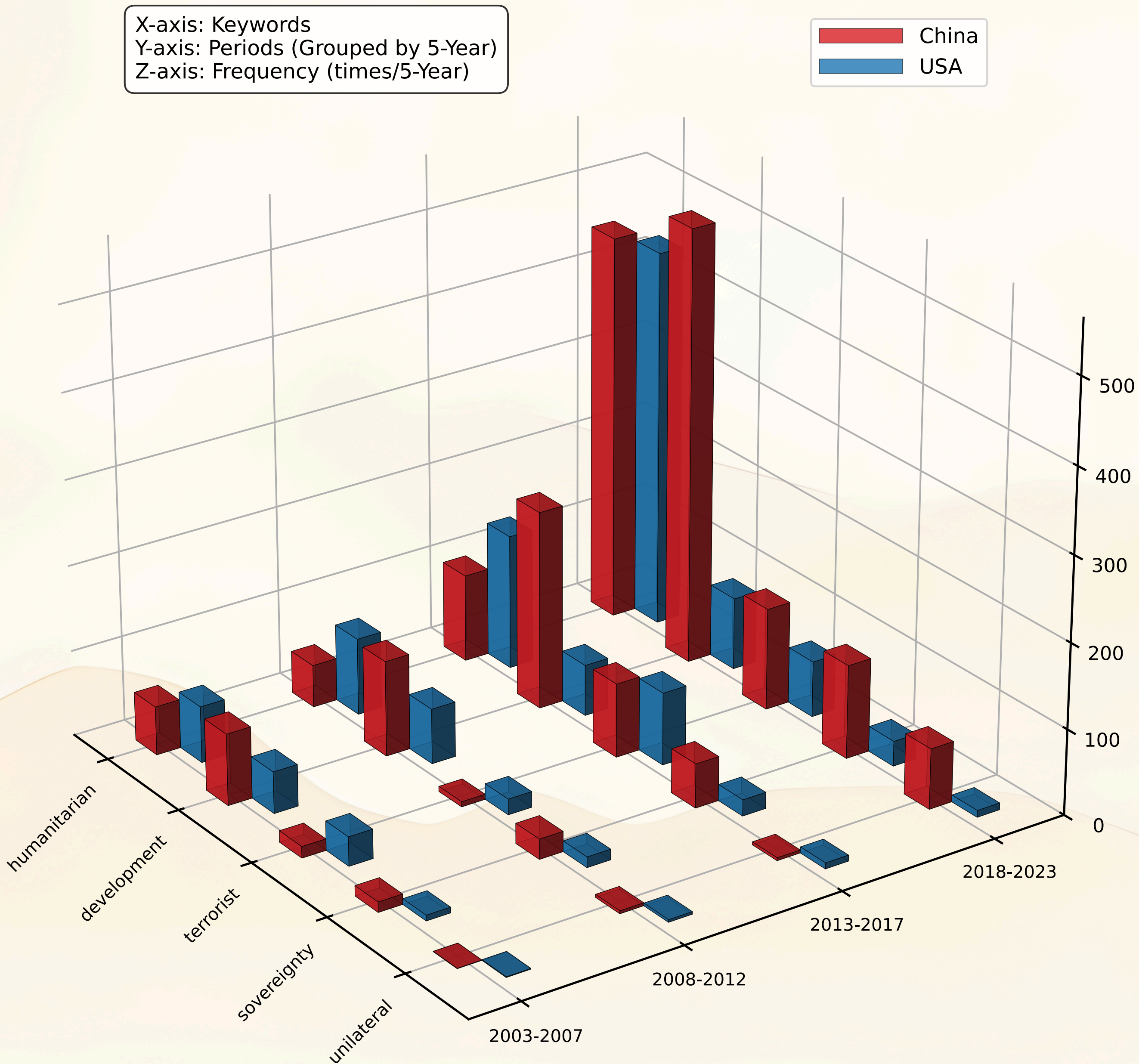
BEYOND PERCEPTIONS: CHINA'S RHETORIC IN THE UNSC ACROSS LEADERSHIP CHANGE

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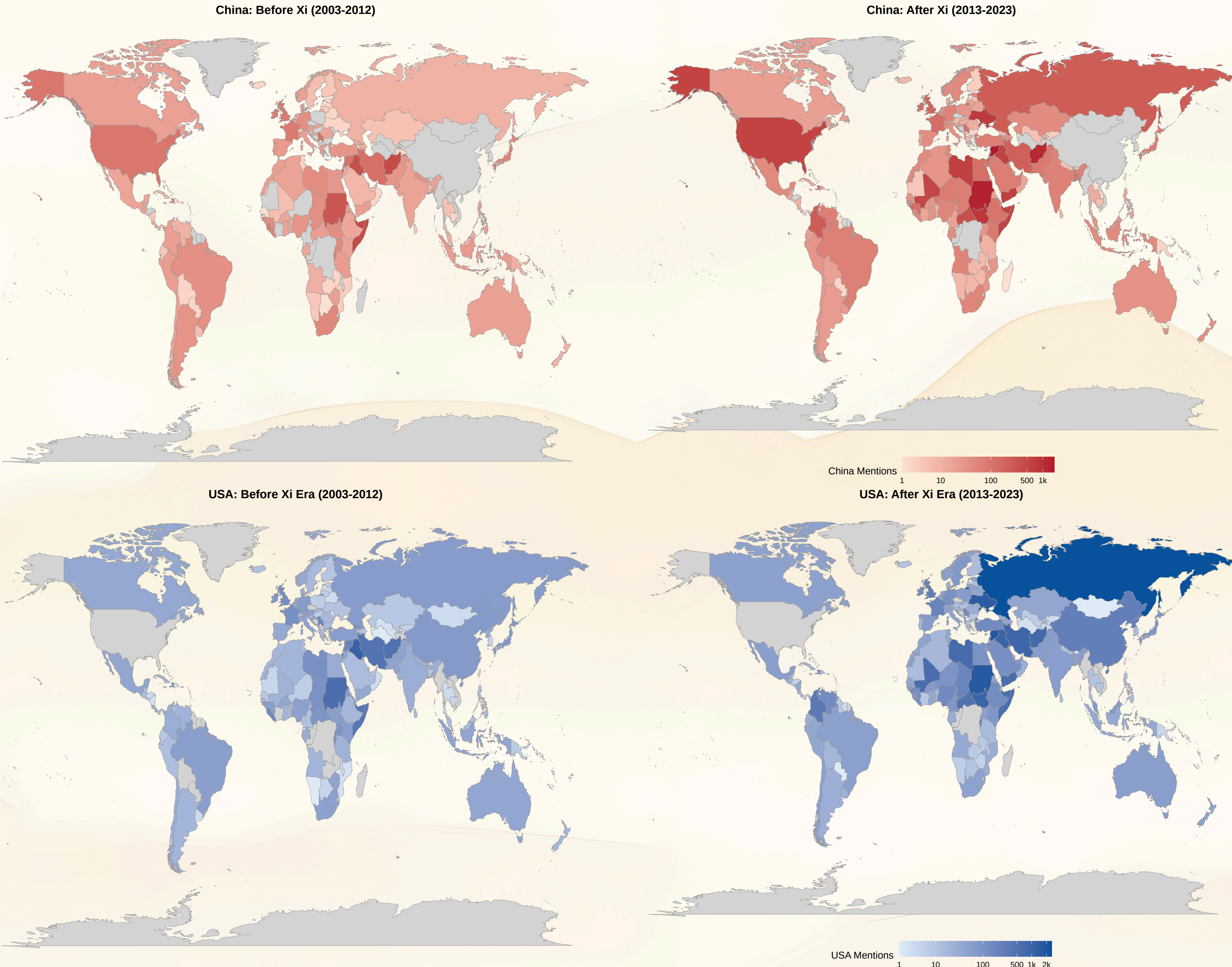
Introduction

Despite widespread claims that China has become increasingly assertive globally and is preparing for possible conflict in regions such as Taiwan and the South China Sea, it remains unclear whether these perceptions align with China’s actual diplomatic rhetoric in multilateral settings. Given that the UNSC is the world’s central arena for crisis deliberation and norm contestation, examining China’s statements here offers a unique lens to test whether its discourse truly mirrors its perceived assertiveness and potential war intentions, or whether these perceptions are exaggerated. By moving beyond perceptions, we aim to clarify how China’s global ambitions and security concerns are truly reflected—or not—in its multilateral diplomacy.

China vs USA Keyword Frequency

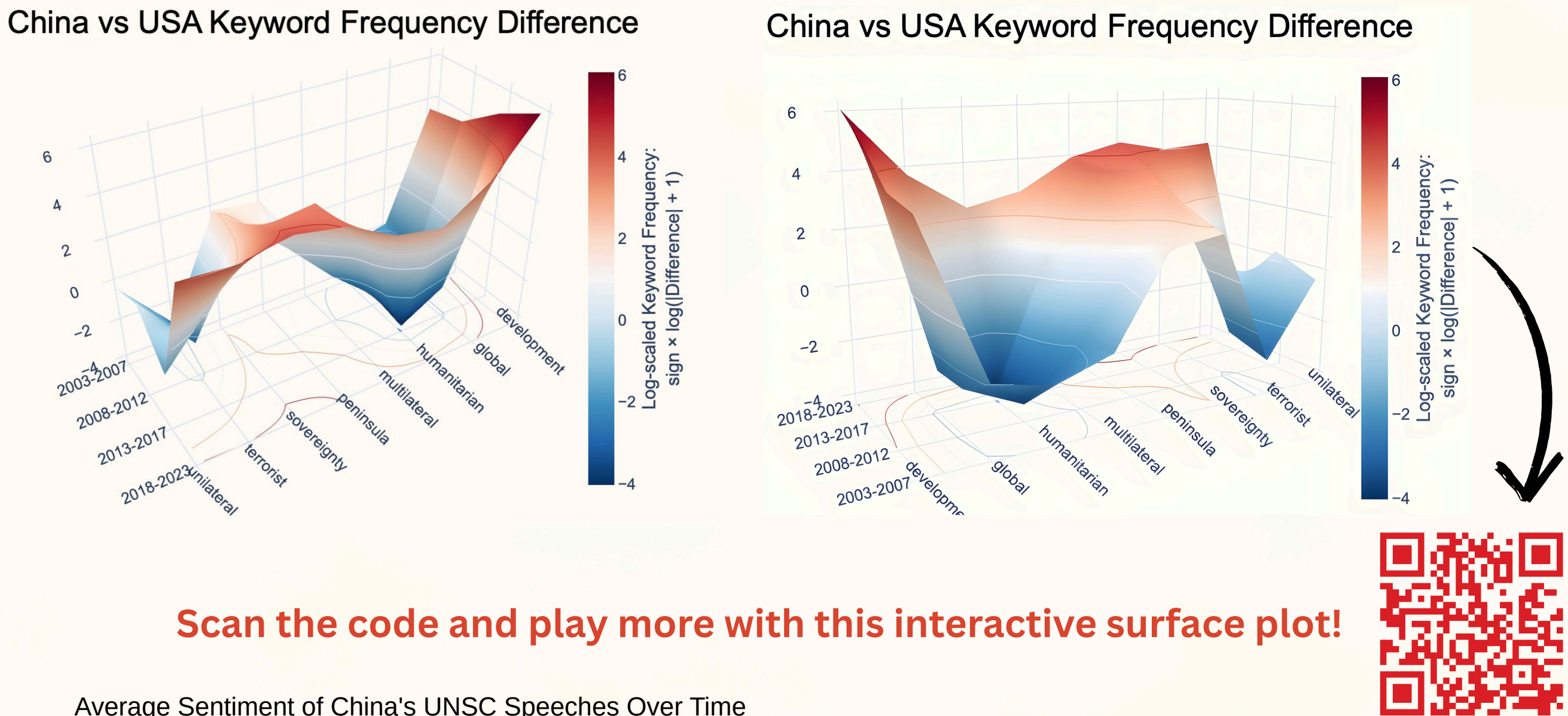


After the leadership change in 2013, China’s frequency of **all depicted keywords in UNSC speeches** has increased compared to earlier years, with **especially strong rising trends for “development” and “sovereignty”**. Further examination of the speeches is needed to determine which topics are most frequently referred to by these keywords.

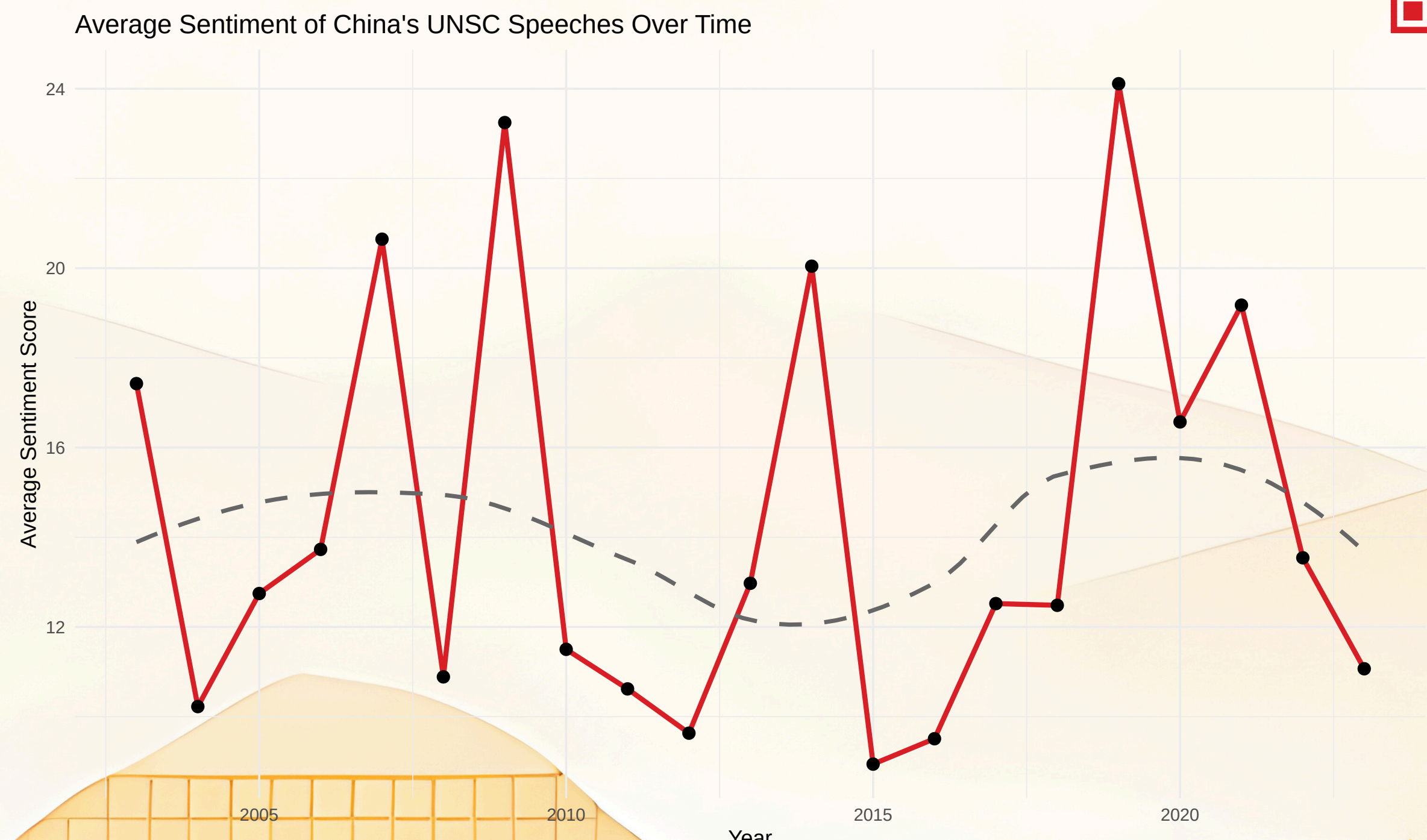


Regarding to China's transformation, this data visually demonstrates that across leadership change, China has developed from **a regional focus into a global standpoint** that now it engages rhetorically on nearly all major international security issues.

Mentions of countries and regions were extracted and geocoded to visualize geopolitical shifts in China’s and the United States’ UNSC speeches.



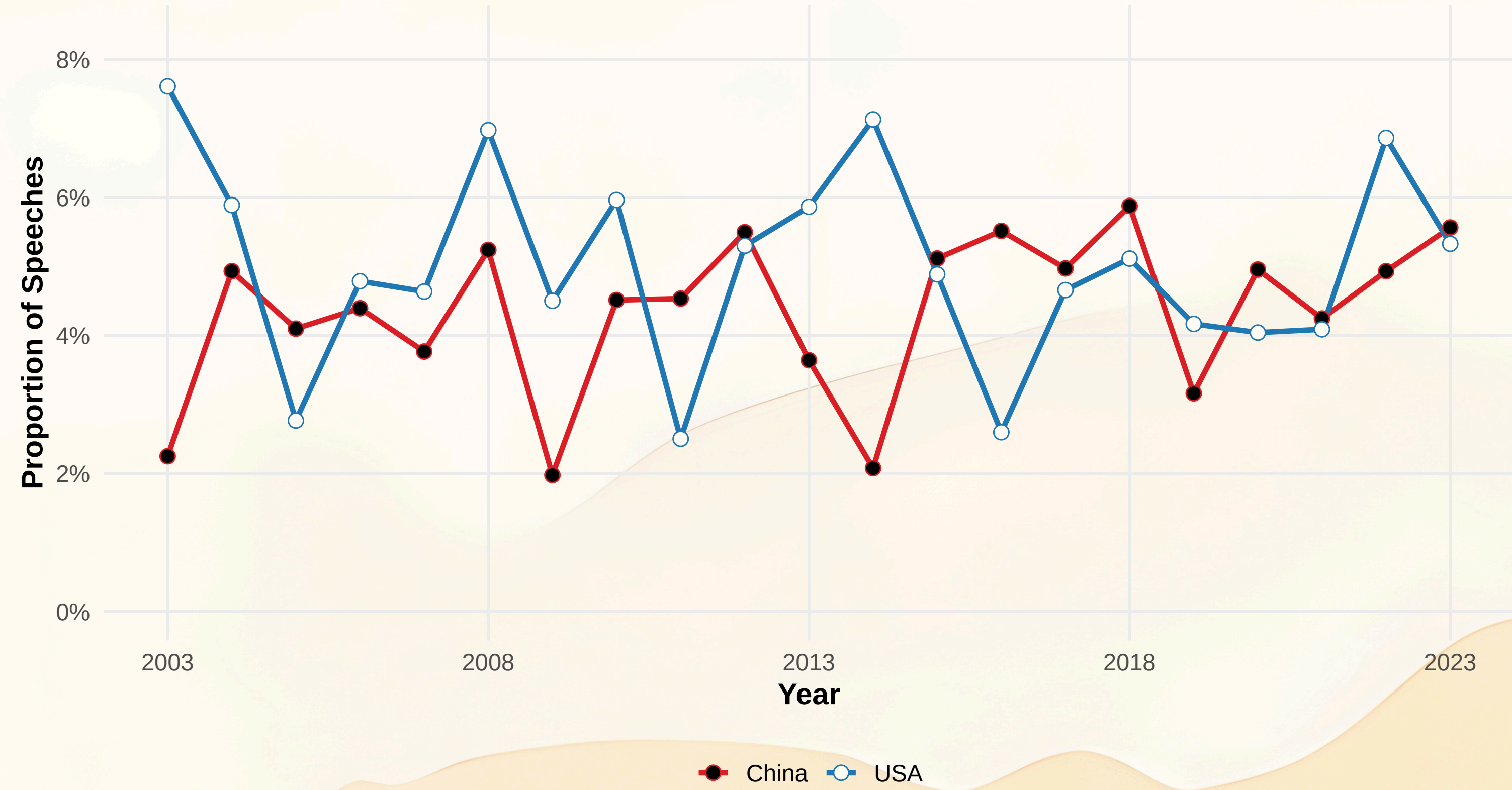
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- **2003-2014:** The diplomatic tone became **more critical** as China developed its voice on the world stage.
- **2014-2020:** Rhetoric shifted to be **more positive**, framing China as a constructive global leader.
- **Post-2020:** The tone has **hardened again** in response to rising geopolitical pressures.

We used sentimental analysis (syuzhet method) to track long-term trends in the tone of diplomatic language. Each speech was scored based on its net count of positive vs. negative words. The scores were then averaged annually (red line) and a smoothed trendline (dashed line) was added to reveal the underlying shifts over time.

Share of Speeches in UNSC by Country (2003-2023)



Because of no obvious shift across leadership change, here the data suggests that **China is not desiring to "talk more" than USA, but rather to talk as much as it**. The goal appears to be achieving rhetorical parity, not dominance.

We aggregated the total number of speeches per year for China and the United States to track trends in discursive presence at the UNSC.

Conclusion

Our analysis shows that while China has become more active and globally engaged in its UNSC rhetoric, this neither confirms nor rejects perceptions of a turn toward aggressive or war-oriented intentions. Instead, China’s speeches reveal a shift from cautious criticism to more constructive engagement, and a desire to match the rhetorical presence of other major powers. These patterns reflect China’s evolving approach to multilateral diplomacy without providing clear evidence of confrontational or expansionist goals.